

STUDY SHEET - BLOCK 1: CHAPTER ONE (Scrooge)

1. Plot (Trama)

The story begins on Christmas Eve in 19th-century London. The narrator makes it clear that Jacob Marley is dead; he was Scrooge's business partner and Scrooge was his only friend. Ebenezer Scrooge is a greedy, cold-hearted old man who works in his counting-house (ufficio). He makes his clerk, Bob Cratchit, work in a freezing room because Scrooge is too stingy to buy more coal for the fire.

During the day, Scrooge receives three visitors:

1. His cheerful nephew, **Fred**, who comes to wish him a "Merry Christmas" and invites him to Christmas dinner. Scrooge refuses aggressively, using his famous phrase: "*Bah! Humbug!*" (Sciocchezze!).
2. **Two gentlemen** who ask for a charitable donation to help the poor and hungry. Scrooge refuses to give them any money, saying that the poor should go to prisons or workhouses.
3. A young boy singing a Christmas carol at his door, whom Scrooge scares away.

At the end of the day, Scrooge unwillingly gives Bob Cratchit the day off for Christmas, but demands that he comes to work very early the day after. Scrooge then goes home to his dark and cold house.

2. Characters (Personaggi)

- **Ebenezer Scrooge:** The protagonist. An old, miserable businessman. He is isolated from society, hates Christmas, and his only interest in life is making money. He is completely lacking in empathy.
- **Jacob Marley:** A dead businessman and Scrooge's former partner. His death is established at the very beginning to set the supernatural tone for the rest of the story.
- **Bob Cratchit:** An office clerk who works for Scrooge. He is poor, overworked, and physically cold, but he remains humble, patient, and keeps the Christmas spirit alive.
- **Fred:** Scrooge's nephew. He is the exact opposite of Scrooge: warm, joyful, and full of the Christmas spirit. He believes Christmas is a time for kindness and family.

3. Themes (Tematiche)

- **Avarice and Greed (Avarizia e Avidità):** Scrooge represents the extreme obsession with money, which makes him blind to the suffering of others and completely alone.
- **The Christmas Spirit (Lo spirito del Natale):** Contrasted through Fred (who sees Christmas as a time of love and charity) and Scrooge (who sees it as a waste of time and money).
- **Poverty and Social Injustice (Povertà e Ingiustizia sociale):** Highlighted by Bob Cratchit's terrible working conditions and the two gentlemen describing the situation of the poor in London. Scrooge's cruel suggestion that the poor should go to workhouses or die reflects the harsh attitudes of the Victorian upper class.

4. Useful Vocabulary (Vocabolario utile)

- **Greedy / Stingy:** Avido / Tirchio
- **Counting-house:** Ufficio contabile
- **Clerk:** Impiegato
- **Workhouse:** Ospizio / Casa di lavoro per i poveri (luogo terribile dell'epoca vittoriana)
- **Charity:** Beneficenza
- **Humbug:** Fandonia, sciocchezza (l'espressione tipica di Scrooge per disprezzare il Natale)
- **To freeze:** Congelare (riferito al freddo nell'ufficio di Bob Cratchit)

5. Possible Questions & Short Answers (Domande per la verifica)

- **Q1: Who was Jacob Marley and what was his relationship with Scrooge?**
Answer: Jacob Marley was a businessman who died seven years ago. He was Scrooge's business partner, and Scrooge was his only friend.
- **Q2: How does Scrooge treat his clerk, Bob Cratchit?**
Answer: Scrooge treats Bob terribly. He pays him very little and doesn't let him use enough coal for the fire, leaving Bob freezing in the office.
- **Q3: How does Scrooge react to his nephew's invitation for Christmas dinner?**
Answer: Scrooge refuses angrily, saying that Christmas is a waste of time and money. He uses his famous phrase "*Bah! Humbug!*".
- **Q4: What is Scrooge's attitude towards the poor?**
Answer: When two gentlemen ask him for charity, Scrooge refuses. He says that his taxes

already pay for prisons and workhouses, and that the poor should go there or die to decrease the surplus population.